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Version One Ventures' Boris Wertz wants Canadians to compete internationally

By [Kia Kokalitcheva](#)

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Vancouver-based venture firm [Version One](#) is a chameleon among Canadian investors: It's based up north, but often shows up on the cap tables of US startup stars. And while it made big bets in SaaS software 10 years ago, it's constantly nurturing new interests, including backing ambitious founders in India.

Canada's startup ecosystem is young and continues to reckon with what it needs to do to catch up to its southern neighbor. But according to Version One founder and general partner Boris Wertz, looking outside of its national borders is what the industry should do to strengthen itself.

Wertz sat down with PitchBook for a wide-ranging conversation about venture capital during the Web Summit conference in Vancouver last month. The following interview has been edited for length and clarity.

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PitchBook: It sounds like you've sort of decided that you have to keep evolving your areas of focus—tell me about that.

Wertz: I think that that's the only way you survive, right? Because if you specialize, every wave is gonna run out at some stage. SaaS was an amazing place to invest in years ago—I'm not sure if it's an amazing place to invest today. ... And so I think there's certain waves that emerge, and they have a certain shelf life, be it three years, five years, sometimes perhaps even 10 years. But at some stage, they're gonna mature, the most interesting opportunities are gone, right? The value in those waves accrues to the incumbents.

And so, yeah, we think about continuously reinventing ourselves. Thinking about new waves, building out our deal flow, our network, in that way. Because then obviously your network can't stay stale, right? Like the folks that provide me India deal flow are very different from the folks that provide us robotics deal flow, to the folks that gave us SaaS deal flow 10 years ago.

Why invest in India right now?

Generally, we don't really think about geography, per se. We were always focused on North America. Canada was always a big part, just because we're based here and Canada was overlooked for some time. So [we] started spending some time [in India] two years ago, just because I found it fascinating what's happening there. And our thesis is: Can India be "China from two decades ago"?

I think our investment thesis there is based on three pillars. The first one is: India has these characteristics that it could become the next China, like population growth, rise of the middle class, the "China+1" strategies—literally people trying to get less dependent on China. And India is in a great position to capture lots of the manufacturing and technology, etc.

But then also exceptional entrepreneurs—hustle, smarts, ambition.

And then last but not least, for us as an international investor, there's actually not many institutional seed funds of our size [that] can come in and price a \$2-3 million seed round. There's lots of really small funds that can do a pre-seed round, there's lots of these Series A funds like [Sequoia](#), [Accel](#), [Lightspeed](#), [Matrix](#), [Bessemer](#)... ... but very few that are in between. So we feel like there's a real lack of capital in a certain segment.

We love the general opportunity of "India for India," and we think India has some of the best entrepreneurs.

One of the things that I'm fascinated by when it comes to Version One is: You guys are based in Canada, but you don't invest in Canada specifically, unlike most other venture funds here. Tell me about that.

First of all, I think if we found all the great entrepreneurs we want to meet in Canada, we would only invest in Canada. So I don't think it's a strategy to say, "we don't want to invest in Canada," or "we only invest 20% of our fund in Canada." And actually, in the first fund, we invested around 50-50 [between the] US and Canada.

There's three things I would say. The first one is: I don't believe that any fund that is geographically restricted can create the best returns, because you never have the choice. You don't even know what a great entrepreneur looks like. Within your pool, you might see the best entrepreneurs, but that might be a local maximum. There might be much better entrepreneurs working on the same opportunity, just in the ecosystem next to you. So I think to be really competitive, to have the best potential filter, you need to be geographically agnostic, right? I mean within reason.

I think a second thing is on a more fund-specific level. ... We have just pushed forward on more deal flow in the US. ... Like, in the beginning, you always start a little bit closer to

home. So that's why Fund One we did more in Canada. Over time, we built up more deal flow in the US.

And then last but not least: I think just the stuff that we've been interested in as of late, we haven't really seen that much emerge in Canada. I mean, crypto, for example, there's not that many crypto companies in Canada—[Dapper Labs](#) is the only one at scale, which we invested in. Robotics, there's not that much—I mean, we have done one robotics investment in Canada.

You spent some time at Andreessen Horowitz as a board partner—tell me about that.

There was a time when [Andreessen Horowitz](#), I think they were eight or nine GPs, started to scale very quickly, and I have to give it to Marc [Andreessen] and Ben [Horowitz] for continuously iterating on thinking about how to scale a firm—what are new ideas? And their idea was: If we don't have enough GPs to sit on a board relative to the opportunities we have, why don't we get people, mostly operators, that can sit on behalf of us on the board, either in verticals that we don't really fully understand, or we don't have a specific expertise, or in geographies where it's a little harder to travel to?

The firm recognized relatively quickly it didn't really scale. It was too much friction between the GP who wrote the check and the board partner who represented the check. ... It's always a little tough when the investor who is actually responsible for writing the check is not necessarily the person representing that firm on the board. So they never really formally stopped it, but it kind of died a slow death, right? But it was fascinating to see. I was for two or three years, very close to the firm, and it was some of the most fun years as they quickly expanded.

So obviously I have to ask about AI—where are you guys playing in that?

I think it's a very tough space to play in right now. We have a bunch of portfolio companies [that] I think have benefited in a big way from all the [large language model] improvements over the last few years. Product roadmaps have accelerated, and the market opportunity has gotten bigger, etc. But [as you know] AI is super, super competitive, super noisy, [there's] lots of obvious ideas, multiple teams going after the same idea. The only moat seems to be speed of execution, right? And that feels it's sometimes tough to evaluate at the seed stage. ... It feels like it's such a momentum-, hype-driven sector right now, right?

[It's] so against our investment style, or so different than our investment style. So we're trying to find a good entry point into it, so we'll see what that is.

I heard that you are raising your next fund—are you?

We're pretty much done with that. Yeah, I mean same team, same strategy, same fund size.

Have you been doing any secondaries, or anything else liquidity-wise?

We have always done fund secondaries. So where we have institutional investors that are super interested in buying some positions, we connect them with our individual LPs if somebody wants to have secondary. We always felt like that was a much better way of creating liquidity. ... We want to play out the outliers—let's go all the way and optimize returns for that. But if there are LPs that need liquidity in between, we can solve that on an LP basis, versus having to sell too early.

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About [Kia Kokalitcheva](#)

Kia Kokalitcheva leads PitchBook’s US venture capital news team and is based in San Francisco. With over a decade of experience covering Silicon Valley, startups, VCs, and the broader dealmaking world, she brings deep expertise and curiosity to the newsroom. Kia previously worked at Axios, Fortune, and VentureBeat. She holds a bachelor’s degree in Political Economy from UC Berkeley, where she was a columnist for its award-winning student newspaper, The Daily Californian.

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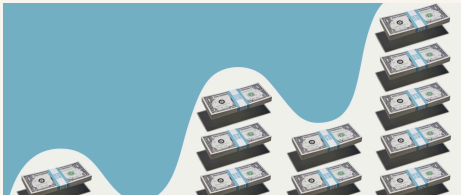
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